

(From left) **Narthaki Nataraj**, *Bharatanatyam dancer and Planning Commission member, Tamil Nadu;* **Aruna Sairam,** *Carnatic music maestro and composer*

▲ THE FEMALE GAZE: REVOLUTIONISING THE ARTS

TAKEAWAYS

"Give respect to yourself. Go through with things. Don't expect support to reach your true potential. Just love yourself. That's enough for your career achievement"

Narthaki Nataraj

"*Shraddha* and *saburi*. That means conviction and relentless pursuit on the one hand and patience on the other. These two qualities will get you where you want to go in any field"

Aruna Sairam

hesitations, insults." Over the years, Nataraj became well-versed in the art of ignoring, through which she commanded respect. "Society never coined any respectable name for us. I'm not an exhibit for this society. I always feel the queen." Nataraj coined the word 'Thirunangai', which is used to refer to members of the community in Tamil Nadu.

Lavanya Nalli values Nataraj's persistence and knows it is a necessary attribute for women to thrive in any field. In her first stint in the family-run business, she faced resistance. "I would say that I was tolerated. It was more this mindset of 'okay, let her do something till she gets married'." After having earned her stripes by working with McKinsey in the US, Nalli felt she earned "more credibility" on her return for a second stint in the company. She addressed how "support systems" are the need of the hour for married working women to ensure they don't leave the workforce.

Empowerment through economic self-sufficiency and financial stability is vital for Megha Asher. In a session on promoting women's entrepreneurship, she singled out social media as boosting the entrepreneural spirit "where the sky is the limit". She feels women need to let go of the martyr mentality. "We sometimes like to say 'Oh, no, you know, you're more important. You need to do this. I will step back. That approach needs to stop." Nalini Parthiban has seen first-hand the potential of social media by running a digital-first brand with Sweet Karam Coffee and also how networking can boost brand's profile. She said there's a lot of awareness and support from women entrepreneurs in the start-up ecosystem. "If there is another woman, there is always a softer cushion," she noted. Her word of advice: "Get comfortable being uncomfortable every day.... Be a solution finder, not a problem seeker."

Workplace environs need to be better too as a 2023 Deloitte report revealed that working women in India have high stress levels. Dr Pratima Murthy noted how women are more likely to have common mental disorders like depression and anxiety